

THE SLOW ATLAS

Italy

The Complete Guide

Where to go, what to eat, and how to travel it slowly.



A SLOW ATLAS GUIDE • VOLUME III

WELCOME

Benvenuti – welcome

There is nowhere quite like Italy. In one trip you can stand in a two-thousand-year-old arena, eat the best plate of pasta of your life at a paper-clothed trattoria, drift down a canal at dusk, and watch the sun set over cypress-lined Tuscan hills. It is art, food and la dolce vita – and endlessly, gloriously walkable.

This guide is built to help you travel slowly and well: to understand the country, plan with confidence, and leave room for the long lunches and aimless piazzas that become the best memories – from your first train question to your last scoop of gelato.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- Before you go – timing, paperwork & packing
- Budget – what it really costs, with sample spends
- Destinations – Rome, Florence, Venice & beyond
- Four ready-to-use itineraries, 7 to 14 days
- Getting around – trains, driving & the ZTL trap
- Where to stay, what to eat, what to do
- Culture, etiquette, coffee rules & a phrasebook

HOW TO TRAVEL IT SLOWLY

- Do two or three cities, not ten – Italy rewards it.
- Take the long lunch; let the afternoon disappear.
- Eat regionally; the dish changes every 50 km.
- Learn ten words; 'buongiorno' opens every door.
- Wander the backstreets, away from the main sights.
- Master the coffee rules and you'll pass for a local.

LOCAL TIP

Carry small change, an appetite and an empty afternoon – the piazza at aperitivo hour fills the last one better than any plan.



PART ONE

Before you go

Timing, paperwork and packing – sorted.



IN THIS PART

When to go & festivals
Documents, health & money
What to pack

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When to go

01

Italy is a year-round joy, but two shoulder seasons are the sweet spot — warm, luminous and (a little) less crowded.

Spring APR – JUN	Mild, green, blossoming; ideal for cities and the countryside. Easter and June get busy.
Autumn SEP – OCT	Harvest light, warm sea, truffles & wine. Arguably the finest season of all.
Summer JUL – AUG	Hot and packed; August (Ferragosto) sees cities empty and many shops shut. Head for the coast or the Alps.
Winter NOV – MAR	Quiet, atmospheric and cheaper; Christmas markets, opera season, and skiing in the Dolomites.

A MONTH-BY-MONTH ALMANAC

MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS	MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS
Jan	Cold, quiet	Sales; ski the Alps	Jul	Hot, crowded	Coast & lakes
Feb	Cold, crisp	Venice Carnival	Aug	Hottest; closures	Ferragosto (15th)
Mar	Warming	Fewer crowds	Sep	Warm, superb	Harvest, warm sea
Apr	Mild, lovely	Easter; spring bloom	Oct	Mild, golden	Truffles & wine
May	Warm, ideal	Perfect cities	Nov	Cool, wet	Quiet, cheap
Jun	Warm, busy	Long light evenings	Dec	Cold, festive	Markets, opera

LOCAL TIP

Avoid mid-August if you can: many city restaurants and shops close for Ferragosto, while the coast is at its priciest and most crowded.



Documents, health & money

02

ENTRY & VISAS

- EU citizens: just an ID card. Many others (UK, US, Australia, Canada...) enter visa-free for up to 90 days in any 180 (Schengen) – confirm your rule.
- Passport valid 3+ months beyond departure (non-EU).
- The EU's ETIAS travel authorisation is expected soon – check before you fly.
- No mandatory vaccines; carry your EHIC/GHIC (EU/UK) or insurance.

HEALTH & SAFETY NET

- Excellent healthcare; pharmacies (farmacia, green cross) are everywhere and helpful.
- Tap water is safe; refill at street fountains (nasoni in Rome).
- Take travel insurance for delays, theft & non-EU medical cover.
- Summer heat is intense – hydrate and pace the midday.

MONEY

- Currency: the euro (€) – $\approx$ £0.85 / \$1.08 per € (indicative).
- Cards are widely accepted; carry some cash for small bars, markets & rural spots.
- A 'coperto' (cover charge) and sometimes 'servizio' appear on the bill – normal.
- Tipping isn't expected; rounding up or a euro or two is a kind gesture.

CONNECTIVITY

- EU roaming is free for EU SIMs; others: an eSIM or local SIM (TIM, Vodafone, WindTre).
- Coverage is good; free Wi-Fi in many cafés & piazzas.
- Google Maps handles trains, buses & walking beautifully.

LOCAL TIP

Prices and opening hours shift with the season, and big sights change their booking rules – always re-check the official site a few days before you go.



What to pack

03

You'll walk on cobbles for miles and dress a notch smarter than you might elsewhere — Italians prize 'la bella figura'. Pack light, comfortable and put-together.

CLOTHING

- Comfortable but smart walking shoes (cobble!)
- One neat outfit for dinner & the opera
- Shoulders & knees covered for churches (a scarf helps)
- Layers for changeable spring/autumn
- Sun hat, sunglasses & swimwear in season
- A light rain jacket / compact umbrella

ESSENTIALS

- Refillable water bottle (free street fountains)
- Power adapter (Type C/F/L, 230V) + power bank
- A day bag that zips (pickpocket-proof)
- Any prescriptions in original packaging
- A foldable tote for market finds
- Sunscreen & a small first-aid kit

SMART TO HAVE

- Pre-booked tickets (Colosseum, Vatican, Uffizi, Last Supper) saved offline
- A little cash for coperto & small bars
- Offline maps & a translation app
- A scarf or shawl — for churches, sun and evening cool

LOCAL TIP

Pack one outfit smarter than you think you need. Italians dress well even for a coffee, and you'll feel more at home for matching them.



PART TWO

Budget

What it really costs – from an espresso to a feast.



IN THIS PART

Daily budgets, low to lavish

A sample ten-day spend

Prices to anchor on

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What Italy costs

Italy spans every budget — a €1 espresso at the bar, a €4 slice of pizza al taglio, or a Michelin tasting menu. Here's what to expect per person, per day, on the ground.

STYLE	PER DAY	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Budget	€60–100	Hostels/B&Bs, market & street food, trains, walking
Comfort	€150–260	3–4□ hotels & agriturismi, trattorie, some high-speed trains
Luxury	€400+	Design hotels & masserie, fine dining, drivers, private guides

SAMPLE 10-DAY COMFORT BUDGET

ITEM	€
Accommodation (9 nights)	1,150
Food & drink	650
Trains & transport	350
Sights, tours & entries	350
Extras & buffer	300

≈ €2,800 · about £2,380 / \$3,020 for two weeks scale up

PRICES TO ANCHOR ON

- Espresso at the bar: €1.00–1.50
- Cappuccino: €1.50–2.00
- Pizza / pasta main: €8–14
- Glass of house wine: €4–6
- Aperitivo (spritz + snacks): €8–12
- Gelato: €2.50–4
- Museum entry: €12–25
- Rome–Florence fast train: €30–50
- City B&B double: €90–150
- Taxi from airport: €40–55

LOCAL TIP

Drink your coffee standing at the bar (*al banco*) — it's often half the price of sitting, and it's how Italians do it.



PART THREE

Destinations

The unmissable places, region by region.



IN THIS PART

The lie of the land

Rome · Florence · Venice

Which base is for you?

A short history & the arts

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The lie of the land

05

Italy runs the length of a peninsula, from Alpine north to sun-baked south. Don't sweep it all — pick a region or two and go deep.

The North

Milan's style, Venice's canals, the Lakes & the Dolomites; risotto & Prosecco.

The Centre

Rome's ruins, Florence's art, Tuscany & Umbria's hill towns and wine.

The South

Naples, the Amalfi Coast, Pompeii, Puglia — sun, sea and the best pizza.

The islands

Sicily and Sardinia: ancient temples, volcanoes and turquoise coves.

INSIDER TIP

Each region has its own colour on the map opposite — and its own kitchen. First visit? Ride the classic triangle: Rome, Florence, Venice, and add one region.



Schematic — not to scale

Rome

The Eternal City is a living palimpsest: emperors, popes and Vespas layered over three thousand years. Grand, chaotic and endlessly moreish — give it three or four days and it never lets go.

DON'T MISS

- The Colosseum, Roman Forum & Palatine
- The Vatican: St Peter's & the Sistine Chapel
- The Pantheon, still perfect after 1,900 years
- Trevi Fountain, the Spanish Steps & Piazza Navona
- Trastevere's lanes at aperitivo hour

EAT & DRINK

- Carbonara, cacio e pepe, supplì & artichokes
- Pizza al taglio and a proper Roman gelato
- Testaccio market for a food tour
- An evening spritz on a piazza

GOOD TO KNOW

- Book the Colosseum & Vatican online, first slot.
- It's walkable, but hot — plan around the midday.
- Watch pockets on the metro & at Termini.
- Base in Monti or Trastevere for atmosphere.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Two airports; the Leonardo Express to Termini.
- Compact centre — walk, with the metro for hops.
- A great rail hub north & south.
- Skip a car entirely (ZTL everywhere).

LOCAL TIP

Rome runs on heat and timing — book the Colosseum and Vatican for the first morning slot, and save the piazzas for the cool of the evening.



Florence & Tuscany

07

The cradle of the Renaissance is a walkable jewel of art, and the gateway to Tuscany's cypress hills, wine roads and honey-stone towns.

DON'T MISS

- The Duomo & Brunelleschi's dome
- The Uffizi & Michelangelo's David (book ahead)
- Ponte Vecchio & sunset at Piazzale Michelangelo
- Day trips: Siena, San Gimignano, Chianti
- The Val d'Orcia's cypress-lined roads

EAT & DRINK

- Bistecca alla fiorentina, ribollita, lampredotto
- A Chianti or Brunello tasting
- Gelato from an artisan gelateria
- Cicchetti-style wine bars (enoteche)

GOOD TO KNOW

- Pre-book the Uffizi & Accademia to skip queues.
- The centre is small — walk the Oltrarno's quiet side.
- For Tuscany, hire a car (but not for the city).
- Spring & autumn are glorious; August is hot.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- 1h30 from Rome, ~2h to Venice by fast train.
- Walkable core; buses & trains to the hill towns.
- A car unlocks the countryside.
- Pisa & Bologna airports are close.

LOCAL TIP

Do Florence on foot and Tuscany by car — but never bring the car into the city; park outside the ZTL and walk the Renaissance in.



Venice & the North

A city built on water, unlike anywhere on earth — and a springboard to the Dolomites, the Lakes and Milan's style. Stay a night to have it after dark.

DON'T MISS

- St Mark's Basilica & the Doge's Palace
- A gondola or the No. 1 vaporetto down the Grand Canal
- Getting lost in Cannaregio & Dorsoduro
- Murano glass & Burano's painted houses
- North: Lake Como, Verona & the Dolomites

EAT & DRINK

- Cicchetti & an ombra (small wine) in a bacaro
- Sarde in saor, risotto, fresh lagoon seafood
- A spritz on a canal-side campo
- North: risotto, polenta & Prosecco

GOOD TO KNOW

- Stay overnight — it's magic once day-trippers leave.
- Follow yellow signs (per Rialto / San Marco).
- Acqua alta (high water) can flood low areas Nov–Jan.
- It's costly; eat where the locals do (bacari).

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Marco Polo airport + water/land transfers.
- No cars — walk & take the vaporetto.
- Fast trains to Milan (~2h30) & the north.
- A base for Verona, the Lakes & Dolomites.

LOCAL TIP

Stay the night. Venice belongs to whoever is still there after the day-trippers leave — the empty campos at dusk are the real city.



Naples, Amalfi & the South

IO

South of Rome, Italy turns up the colour and the volume — chaotic Naples, the vertiginous Amalfi Coast, Pompeii's ghosts and whitewashed Puglia.

DON'T MISS

- Naples' old town, pizza & archaeological museum
- Pompeii & Herculaneum beneath Vesuvius
- The Amalfi Coast — Positano, Ravello, boat days
- Capri & the Blue Grotto
- Puglia's trulli, sea caves & baroque Lecce

EAT & DRINK

- The world's best pizza (Naples)
- Lemon everything on the Amalfi Coast
- Seafood, mozzarella di bufala, sfogliatella
- Puglia: orecchiette, burrata & focaccia

GOOD TO KNOW

- Naples is intense — streetwise, and it rewards you.
- Amalfi in summer is packed; go May/June or Sept.
- The coast road is stunning but slow — boat it.
- The far south is best with a car.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Naples: fast train 1h10 from Rome.
- Amalfi by ferry & SITA bus (not a hire car).
- Puglia: fly to Bari/Brindisi, then drive.
- Ferries to Capri, Ischia & the islands.

LOCAL TIP

In summer the Amalfi road crawls — see the coast by ferry instead, and you'll trade traffic for the best views in Italy.



Which base for you?

You can't see it all — and you shouldn't try. Here's how the great bases compare, so you can match the trip to your mood.

BASE	VIBE	BEST FOR
Rome	Ancient, grand, chaotic, eternal	First-timers, history, big sights
Florence	Renaissance art, walkable, refined	Art, Tuscany day trips, couples
Venice	Dreamlike, unique, no cars	Romance, a slow day or two
Tuscany	Vineyards, hill towns, cypress roads	Slow drives, wine, countryside
Amalfi/Naples	Sun, sea, drama & the best pizza	Coast, boats, southern soul
Puglia/Sicily	Whitewashed towns, temples, beaches	Off-peak sun, food, road trips

DID YOU KNOW?

Rome, Florence and Venice sit on one high-speed line: Rome–Florence is 1h30, Florence–Venice about 2h. You can base in each for a few nights and never touch a car.

LOCAL TIP

Can't choose? The classic Rome–Florence–Venice triangle covers most first trips beautifully — three cities, one fast train line, no car needed.



A short history & the arts



A TIMELINE, IN BRIEF

Ancient Rome — from a village to an empire that shaped law, roads & language.

The Middle Ages — city-states, maritime republics & soaring cathedrals.

The Renaissance, 15th c. — Florence reinvents art — Michelangelo, Leonardo, Botticelli.

Baroque & Grand Tour — Rome dazzles; Europe's elite come to marvel.

Unification, 1861 — a patchwork of kingdoms becomes one Italy — young, proud, regional.

DID YOU KNOW?

'Italian' cuisine barely exists — it's a hundred regional kitchens. Order the local speciality, and never expect the same dish twice across the country.

HERITAGE TO SEEK OUT

- Rome: the Colosseum, Forum, Pantheon & Vatican.
- Florence: the Duomo, Uffizi & Michelangelo's David.
- Venice: St Mark's, the Doge's Palace, the canals.
- Pompeii & Herculaneum, frozen by Vesuvius.
- Sicily's Greek temples; Puglia's trulli.

THE LIVING ARTS

- Opera (La Scala, Verona's arena), design & fashion (Milan).
- Cinema — from Fellini to modern auteurs.
- Craft: Murano glass, leather, ceramics, tailoring.
- Wine, olive oil & the art of the table.

LOCAL TIP

Book the headline museums (Uffizi, Vatican, Borghese, the Last Supper) online weeks ahead — the queues without a timed ticket can swallow half a day.



PART FOUR

Ready-to-use itineraries

Four trips, planned for you – adapt and go.



IN THIS PART

7 days · Rome, Florence & Venice

10 days · Rome & the South

14 days · the grand tour

10 days · off the beaten track

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7 days · Rome, Florence & Venice



The classic first trip: three peerless cities on one high-speed line. Fly into Rome, out of Venice — no car needed.

D1-3 Rome

Colosseum & Forum, the Vatican, Trevi & Pantheon, Trastevere by night.

D4-5 Florence

The Duomo, Uffizi & David; sunset at Piazzale Michelangelo.

D6-7 Venice

St Mark's, a gondola or vaporetto, and getting gloriously lost.

MAKE IT YOURS

Add 2-3 days and a Tuscan agriturismo (with a car) between Florence and Venice for the 10-day version.



Schematic — not to scale

10 days · Rome & the South

Rome, then the drama of the Amalfi Coast, Pompeii and Naples — history, sea and the world's best pizza.

D1-4 Rome

The ancient city, the Vatican, and long Roman dinners.

D5-6 Naples

Chaotic, glorious; the archaeological museum & true pizza.

D7 Pompeii

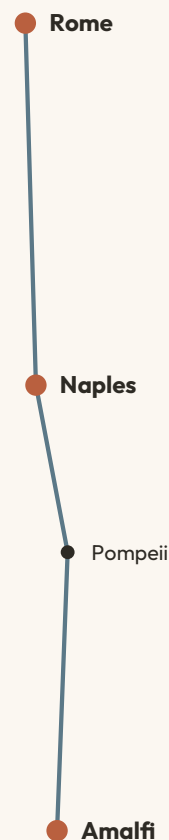
The city frozen by Vesuvius.

D8-10 Amalfi Coast

Positano, Ravello & boat days along the cliffs.

MAKE IT YOURS

Prefer countryside to coast? Swap the Amalfi leg for Tuscany's hill towns and vineyards.



Schematic — not to scale

14 days · The grand tour

Two weeks for the greatest hits plus Tuscany's countryside
— cities, art, wine and cypress roads.

D1-4 Rome

The eternal city, unhurried.

D5-7 Tuscany

Siena, San Gimignano & a vineyard stay (with a car).

D8-9 Florence

Renaissance art and the Oltrarno.

D10-11 Cinque Terre

Cliff villages, coastal walks, seafood.

D12-14 Venice + Verona

Canals, then an opera in Verona's arena on the way out.

MAKE IT YOURS

Short on time? This works at 10 days by trimming
Tuscany to two nights.

Cinque Terre



Schematic — not to scale

10 days · Off the beaten track

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The Italy beyond the big three: whitewashed Puglia and ancient Sicily — sun, temples, food and empty roads.

D1-2 **Bari & the coast**

Old-town espresso and orecchiette made on the doorstep.

D3-4 **Valle d'Itria**

Alberobello's trulli, Ostuni's white lanes, a masseria stay.

D5 **Lecce**

Baroque 'Florence of the South'.

D6-8 **Palermo & west Sicily**

Markets, mosaics, Segesta's temple.

D9-10 **Taormina & Etna**

Cliff-top views and a volcano climb.

MAKE IT YOURS

Two islands in one trip? Fly Puglia to Sicily rather than driving the long way round.



Schematic — not to scale

PART FIVE

Getting around

How the country joins up — and the ZTL you must dodge.



IN THIS PART

The rail network map
Trains, scooters & boats
Tickets & driving

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The rail network

Italy's high-speed trains (Frecciarossa & Italo) glide between the big cities at up to 300 km/h — often faster and calmer than flying. Regional trains reach the rest. This map shows the main spine.



LEGEND

- High-speed (Frecciarossa / Italo)
- - - Intercity & regional
- Local trains & buses (everywhere)

RULES OF THUMB

- Rome–Florence 1h30; Florence–Venice ~2h; Rome–Naples ~1h10.
- Two operators compete (Trenitalia & Italo) — compare fares.
- Book high-speed ahead for cheaper fixed fares.
- Validate paper regional tickets before boarding (green machines).
- Trains beat flying city-to-city once you count airports.

Getting around

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Trains

The best way between cities — Frecciarossa & Italo high-speed, plus a dense regional network. Book ahead for fixed fares; validate paper tickets.



Scooter & Vespa

Iconic and fun on the coast and islands — but chaotic in big cities. Helmet on, confidence required.



Buses & metros

City metros (Rome, Milan, Naples) plus trams & buses; regional buses reach hill towns the train misses.



Ferries & boats

Essential for the islands, the Amalfi Coast and the lakes — and half the romance.

DRIVING — AND THE ZTL TRAP

- A car is a joy in Tuscany, Puglia & the Dolomites — and a liability in cities.
- ZTL (Zona Traffico Limitato): camera-controlled no-go zones in historic centres. Drive in and you'll be fined automatically, by post, weeks later.
- Park outside the centre and walk or take a shuttle.
- Non-EU drivers need an International Driving Permit; autostrade are tolled.
- Petrol is pricey; 'autogrill' stops are an institution.

LOCAL TIP

Never drive into a city's historic centre — those white 'ZTL' signs mean camera-enforced fines. Park at the edge and walk; you'll see more anyway.



Tickets & driving

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TRAIN TICKETS

- Two operators: Trenitalia (Le Freccie) and Italo — compare both.
- High-speed fares are cheapest booked early and fixed to a train.
- Regional tickets are a flat fare — but you **MUST** validate paper ones.
- Buy in the apps (Trenitalia, Italo) or at machines; e-tickets need no validation.
- A rail pass rarely beats point-to-point fares here — do the maths.

CITY TRANSPORT

- Buy metro/bus tickets before boarding (tabacchi, machines, apps).
- Validate on board; fines for fare-dodging are steep.
- Rome, Milan & Naples have handy metros; most centres are walkable.

RENTING A CAR

- Great for Tuscany, Umbria, Puglia, Sicily & the Dolomites.
- Book an automatic early — most are manual.
- International Driving Permit for non-EU licences; full insurance advised.
- Mind the ZTL zones and pay-and-display (strisce blu) parking.

BOATS & SCENIC RIDES

- Amalfi & the lakes are best seen by ferry.
- Cinque Terre: hike or take the little coastal train.
- Venice: the vaporetto water-buses are your metro.

LOCAL TIP

On regional (non-high-speed) paper tickets, stamp them in the green or white machine on the platform before boarding — an unvalidated ticket earns a fine.



PART SIX

Where to stay & what to eat

From agriturismo to al dente.



IN THIS PART

Accommodation & agriturismo
How to eat (and the coffee rules)
What to order, region by region

Accommodation

Italy's lodging is part of the pleasure — a frescoed palazzo, a Tuscan farm stay, a whitewashed trullo. Book cities and the shoulder seasons well ahead.

TYPE	€ / NIGHT	BEST FOR
Hostel / B&B	€40–100	Budget, solo, friendly local hosts
Boutique hotel	€120–250	Character in the historic centre
Agriturismo	€90–200	Tuscany/Umbria farm stays, pools, wine
Masseria / trullo	€120–300	Puglia charm; whitewashed & rustic-chic
Design / luxury	€350+	Palazzo hotels, lakes & coast

WHERE TO BASE YOURSELF

- Rome: Monti or Trastevere for atmosphere; near Termini for transport.
- Florence: the Oltrarno for a quieter, arty side.
- Venice: stay a night — the city is magic once day-trippers leave.
- Tuscany: an agriturismo near Siena, with a car.

BOOKING KNOW-HOW

- City tourist tax (tassa di soggiorno) is paid on arrival, in cash.
- 'Historic centre' means charm — and often stairs, no lift.
- Agriturismi need a car; book dinner there too.
- August coast & Christmas cities sell out — reserve early.

LOCAL TIP

Stay a night in Venice or a Tuscan agriturismo rather than day-tripping — both are transformed once the coaches leave and the light turns gold.



How to eat in Italy

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HOW IT WORKS

- Eat regionally — the local dish is almost always the right order.
- The meal has a rhythm: antipasto, primo (pasta), secondo, dolce — take what you like.
- Lunch ~1-2:30, dinner from 8; kitchens close between.
- A 'coperto' cover charge is normal; tipping isn't expected.
- Trattoria/osteria = homely & good value; ristorante = smarter.

THE COFFEE RULES

- Cappuccino is a morning drink — never after a meal.
- 'Un caffè' means an espresso; drink it standing at the bar (cheaper).
- Order & pay at the till first in busy bars, then show the receipt.
- An 'ammazzacaffè' (a grappa) can follow dinner — coffee, then spirit.

DIETARY NEEDS

- Vegetarian is easy; vegan is growing in cities.
- Coeliac-friendly ('senza glutine') is unusually well catered — Italy tests for it.
- Say 'sono vegetariano/a' or 'senza glutine'.
- Ask about hidden anchovy, lard (strutto) & meat stock.

WHAT TO DRINK

- Regional wine — order the house (della casa); it's usually good.
- Aperitivo: Aperol or Campari spritz, with free snacks ~6-8pm.
- Amaro or grappa to finish; limoncello on the coast.
- 'Acqua frizzante o naturale?' — sparkling or still.
- 'Salute!' — cheers.

LOCAL TIP

Watch where locals eat lunch, not dinner — a busy trattoria at 1pm full of workers on a set menu is Italy's surest sign of a good kitchen.



What to order · the classics

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PASTA & RICE

Carbonara — egg, pecorino, guanciale, pepper — no cream (Rome)

Cacio e pepe — pecorino & black pepper, silky (Rome)

Ragù alla bolognese — the real slow-cooked meat sauce (Bologna)

Pesto alla genovese — basil, pine nuts, parmesan (Liguria)

Risotto — creamy rice — alla milanese with saffron (Milan)

Cacio... amatriciana — tomato, guanciale, pecorino (Lazio)

PIZZA, PLATES & SWEETS

Pizza napoletana — blistered, chewy, from a wood oven (Naples)

Bistecca alla fiorentina — a colossal T-bone, rare (Tuscany)

Parmigiana — baked aubergine, tomato & mozzarella

Fritto misto — crisp fried seafood or vegetables

Gelato — the real thing — from a gelateria artigianale

Tiramisù — coffee, mascarpone, cocoa — heaven

LOCAL TIP

Follow the 'km 0' and 'fatto in casa' (homemade) signs, and eat where the menu is short and regional — that's where Italy cooks best.



What to order · region by region

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NORTH & CENTRE

Milan — risotto giallo, cotoletta, panettone

Bologna — tortellini in brodo, tagliatelle al ragù, mortadella

Venice — cicchetti (bar snacks), sarde in saor, spritz

Florence — bistecca, ribollita, lampredotto street food

Rome — carbonara, cacio e pepe, supplì, carciofi

SOUTH & ISLANDS

Naples — true pizza, sfogliatella, ragù napoletano

Amalfi — lemon everything, fresh seafood, delizia al limone

Puglia — orecchiette, burrata, taralli, focaccia barese

Sicily — arancini, pasta alla Norma, cannoli, granita

Sardinia — culurgiones, porceddu, pecorino & bottarga

MARKET & BAR WISDOM

- Markets (Rome's Testaccio, Bologna's Quadrilatero, Palermo's Ballarò) are a meal in themselves.
- Aperitivo hour: a spritz buys you a spread of free snacks.
- The shortest, hand-written menu is usually the best kitchen.

LOCAL TIP

The dish changes every fifty kilometres — order the town's speciality, not your favourite from home, and let each region surprise you.



Shopping & craft

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WHERE TO SHOP

- Food markets & alimentari for edible souvenirs.
- Artisan streets: Florence leather, Venice's Murano glass, Naples nativity figures.
- Milan for design & fashion; outlet villages nearby.
- Ceramics towns — Deruta, Vietri, Caltagirone.

WORTH CARRYING HOME

- Olive oil, aged balsamic, dried pasta, coffee.
- Parmigiano & vacuum-packed cured meats (check customs).
- Leather, a silk tie, hand-made paper (Florence).
- A bottle of the region's wine or amaro.

BUY SMART

- Tax-free (VAT refund) on €70+ purchases for non-EU visitors — ask for the form.
- Prices are fixed; haggling isn't the culture (except flea markets).
- Beware fake 'designer' goods sold on the street — illegal to buy.
- Real Murano & Florentine leather carry maker's marks.

INSIDER TIP

The best souvenir is edible: a good olive oil, a wedge of Parmigiano or a bottle of the local wine will bring the trip home to your kitchen.

LOCAL TIP

For non-EU visitors, ask for the tax-free (VAT refund) form on purchases over €70, and keep the goods unused for the airport refund desk.



PART SEVEN

Experiences & practical tips

What to do – and how to do it well.



IN THIS PART

Things to do

Culture & etiquette

Safety & every traveller

An Italian phrasebook

THE SLOW ATLAS

Things to do

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ART, RUINS & FAITH

- Walk the Roman Forum & Colosseum at opening, before the heat.
- The Vatican & Sistine Chapel (book the first slot).
- The Uffizi & Michelangelo's David in Florence.
- Pompeii & Herculaneum under Vesuvius.
- A dawn on empty St Mark's Square, Venice.

FOOD & WINE

- A pasta or pizza-making class.
- Wine tasting in Chianti, Barolo or the Prosecco hills.
- A market food tour; truffle-hunting in autumn.
- An evening aperitivo crawl.

SEA, LAKES & HILLS

- Boat the Amalfi Coast or Lake Como.
- Hike the Cinque Terre cliff paths.
- Drive the cypress roads of Val d'Orcia, Tuscany.
- Trek or ski the Dolomites.

LIVING ITALY

- Opera at Verona's arena or La Scala.
- A passeggiata (evening stroll) and gelato.
- A local festa or sagra (food festival).
- Watch the world go by from a piazza café.

LOCAL TIP

Book the big sights for opening time. An empty Colosseum, Sistine Chapel or St Mark's at 8am is a completely different, magical experience.



Culture & etiquette

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DO

- Greet with 'buongiorno' / 'buonasera' on entering shops & bars.
- Dress the part — 'la bella figura' matters.
- Cover shoulders & knees in churches.
- Slow down at meals; they're the main event.
- Learn the coffee rules — you'll blend right in.

DON'T

- Order a cappuccino after lunch (a giveaway!).
- Ask for parmesan on seafood pasta.
- Rush the waiter or expect the bill unasked — request 'il conto'.
- Wear beachwear away from the beach.
- Drive into a ZTL zone (see Transport).

THE IDEAS BEHIND IT

Italy runs on 'la bella figura' — presenting yourself and your table with care — and on deep regional pride. Campanilismo, loyalty to one's own town (and its bell-tower), explains why the food, dialect and rivalries change every valley. Match the courtesy and curiosity you're shown and you'll be welcomed warmly.

IN CHURCHES

- Cover up; St Peter's & the Duomo enforce it.
- Quiet voices; no flash; often no photos inside.
- Some charge a small entry to the dome or treasury.

LOCAL TIP

When in doubt, watch the table beside you — Italians forgive almost anything except a cappuccino ordered after dinner.



Safety & staying well

A SAFE COUNTRY — MIND YOUR POCKETS

- Violent crime is rare; pickpocketing is the real risk.
- Watch bags on the metro, at Termini, and in tourist crush (Rome, Naples, Venice).
- Wear a cross-body zip bag; keep phones off café tables.
- Ignore 'friendship bracelet' and petition scams near big sights.

STAYING WELL

- Summer heat is fierce — hydrate; refill at street fountains.
- Pharmacies (green cross) give excellent minor-ailment advice.
- Standard tap water is safe; bottled is everywhere too.
- Coastal jellyfish & strong currents — heed local flags.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Many shops shut for a midday riposo, and much of August.
- Sundays are quiet; plan around opening hours.
- Carry a little cash for coperto, markets & small towns.
- Strikes (sciopero) can hit transport — check before travel days.

EMERGENCY NUMBERS

- General emergency (EU): 112
- Ambulance 118 · Police 113 · Fire 115
- Your embassy for lost passports

TRAVEL RESPONSIBLY

- Don't sit/eat on monument steps where it's banned (fines in Rome & Venice).
- Support family trattorie & artisans over the tourist traps.
- Refill a bottle; carry out litter on trails.

LOCAL TIP

Keep your bag zipped and in front on crowded transport and around big sights — pickpockets, not danger, are the only real risk in Italy.



For every traveller

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SOLO & SOLO WOMEN

- Very doable and rewarding; usual night-time sense applies.
- Counter dining and passeggiata make solo evenings easy.
- The odd unwanted attention in the south — a firm 'no, grazie' works.

ACCESSIBILITY

- Improving: accessible high-speed trains & many museums.
- But cobbles, steps and old buildings can be tough; Venice has many bridges.
- Book assistance (RFI 'Sala Blu') for trains in advance.

LGBTQ+

- Legal and generally welcoming, especially in big cities.
- Scenes in Milan, Rome, Bologna & Gay Village events.
- More conservative in small towns & the deep south.

FAMILIES & BUSINESS

- Italy adores children — restaurants welcome them warmly.
- Gelato, piazzas & pizza make it an easy family trip.
- Business: greet formally, dress sharply, and never rush the relationship over lunch.

LOCAL TIP

Whoever you are, Italy meets warmth with warmth — a 'buongiorno', a little curiosity about the food, and you'll be treated like a regular.



An Italian phrasebook · I

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ESSENTIALS

Good morning — buongiorno**Good evening** — buonasera**Thank you** — grazie**You're welcome / please** — prego / per favore**Excuse me / sorry** — scusi / mi dispiace**Yes / No** — sì / no**Do you speak English?** — parla inglese?**I don't understand** — non capisco

NUMBERS

1 uno · 2 due · 3 tre · 4 quattro · 5 cinque · 6 sei · 7
 sette · 8 otto · 9 nove · 10 dieci · 100 cento · 1,000
 mille

GETTING AROUND

Where is...? — dov'è...?**How much?** — quanto costa?**Station** — la stazione**Ticket** — il biglietto**A ticket to...** — un biglietto per...**Left / right** — sinistra / destra**Straight on** — sempre dritto**Toilet** — il bagno**Entrance / exit** — entrata / uscita

LOCAL TIP

'Buongiorno' on the way in and 'grazie, arrivederci' on the way out — those three moments of courtesy will change how every shopkeeper treats you.



An Italian phrasebook · II

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AT THE TABLE

A table for two — un tavolo per due**The menu, please** — il menù, per favore**The house wine** — il vino della casa**Still / sparkling water** — acqua naturale /
frizzante**Delicious!** — buonissimo!**The bill, please** — il conto, per favore**I'm vegetarian** — sono vegetariano/a**Cheers!** — salute!

SMALL TALK & SHOPS

How are you? — come sta?**Very well, thanks** — molto bene, grazie**It's beautiful** — è bellissimo**A coffee, please** — un caffè, per favore**Can I pay by card?** — posso pagare con carta?**Goodbye** — arrivederci

HELP

Help! — aiuto!**Hospital** — l'ospedale**Police** — la polizia**I'm lost** — mi sono perso/a

LOCAL TIP

Italians warm instantly to anyone who tries the language. A shaky 'un caffè, per favore' with a smile is always answered in kind.



Resources & a few words

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TRUSTED & OFFICIAL

- Italian tourism — italia.it
- Trains — Trenitalia & Italo (apps/sites)
- Museums — book via official sites (Coopculture, Uffizi, Vatican)
- Weather & alerts — local forecasts; strike calendars
- City passes — Roma Pass, Firenze/Venezia options
- Getting online — EU roaming or an eSIM

INSIDER TIP

Dial 112 for any emergency across Italy (and the EU) — one number, English-speaking operators, connects you to police, ambulance or fire.

A FEW WORDS OF ITALIAN

Good morning — buongiorno

Thank you — grazie

Please — per favore

Excuse me — scusi

How much? — quanto costa?

Delicious! — buonissimo!

Cheers! — salute!

Goodbye — arrivederci

A warm 'buongiorno' is always the right opener.

LOCAL TIP

Bookmark the official ticket sites before you fly — Italy's big museums and the Colosseum sell timed slots that vanish, and third-party resellers overcharge.



Before-you-go checklists

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BEFORE YOU GO

- ☐ Passport valid 3+ months (non-EU)
- ☐ Check visa / ETIAS rules
- ☐ Travel insurance (theft + medical)
- ☐ Pre-book Colosseum, Vatican, Uffizi
- ☐ Trains & first/last night booked
- ☐ EU roaming or an eSIM sorted
- ☐ Note the ZTL zones if driving
- ☐ Museum city-pass decided

DAY BAG

- ☐ Zip cross-body bag (anti-theft)
- ☐ Some cash for coperto & markets
- ☐ Refillable water bottle
- ☐ Scarf for churches & sun
- ☐ Portable charger

PACKING

- ☐ Comfortable smart walking shoes
- ☐ One neat outfit for dinner
- ☐ Shoulders/knees cover for churches
- ☐ Layers + compact umbrella
- ☐ Sun hat, sunglasses, swimwear (season)
- ☐ Type C/F/L adapter + power bank
- ☐ Prescriptions in original packs
- ☐ Foldable tote for the market

DOCUMENTS

- ☐ Passport / ID + copies
- ☐ Insurance & EHIC/GHIC
- ☐ Pre-booked entry tickets (offline)
- ☐ Driving licence + IDP (if driving)
- ☐ Accommodation confirmations

LOCAL TIP

Screenshot this page to your phone – with timed museum slots and train validations, a quick pre-flight check keeps the trip running smoothly.



ONE LAST THING

Go slowly, see deeply

If there's one idea to carry into Italy, it's this: resist the urge to tick off cities. The travellers who fall hardest for this country are the ones who slow down — who nurse a single espresso and watch a piazza wake, who follow a nonna's hand-written menu, who take the long, cypress-lined road with nowhere to be by dark.

Say 'buongiorno'. Learn ten words. Eat what the region eats. Italy will meet your curiosity with a warmth — and a table — you'll remember for years.

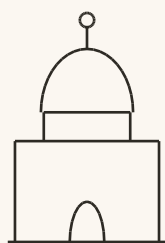
A FEW GOOD RESOURCES

- Italian tourism — italia.it
- Trenitalia & Italo — for the trains
- Official museum sites — for timed tickets
- A ZTL map for any city you'll drive in
- Google Maps (offline) & Translate
- Your travel insurer's 24-hour line

LOCAL TIP

Give one whole day to a single town with no plan — the long lunch and the aimless passeggiata are where Italy quietly steals your heart.





Buon viaggio

Safe travels, and eat well.



THE SLOW ATLAS · RENNES, FRANCE